
A MASTERMIND STUDY COMPANION

AuDHD

Blooming Differently

A guide to understanding, connecting with, and championing Ellis

from the book by Leanne Maskell



How to read this companion

This is built from Leanne Maskell's *AuDHD: Blooming Differently* — a memoir and a guide in equal measure — and reorganised around one purpose: helping you understand Ellis. How he experiences the world, where he'll find strength, where he'll struggle, and how you can show up for him. You share half of this from the inside: you've lived the ADHD wiring since you were twelve. The newer territory is autism, and the particular way the two pull against each other.

Leanne's anchoring image runs through the whole book. A neurotypical brain, she says, is like a **horse** — built to follow a herd. A neurodivergent brain is a **zebra** — wired for self-preservation, impossible to 'break in.' And an AuDHD brain is a **unicorn** — not quite horse, not quite zebra, mystical and magical, with all its complexity rolled into one horn that everyone else seems unable to see. Imagine a zebra growing up in a herd of horses, she writes, unaware of its own distinct wiring. That's the child this book is trying to help you see.

The companion follows the arc of Leanne's own life across thirteen chapters, grouped into three movements. The quiet argument underneath it: Leanne wasn't understood until she was thirty-two, and it cost her decades. Ellis gets understood at nine. That head start is the whole point.

THE THREE MOVEMENTS

I. Understanding the Brain (Chapters 1, 2, 3, 4)

What AuDHD is — and how it shows up in childhood, the teen years, and school.

II. The Hidden Cost (Chapters 5, 6, 7, 8)

What happens to a brain like this when it isn't understood — and how the right support changes everything.

III. Blooming Differently (Chapters 9, 10, 11, 12, 13)

Adulthood, change, the paradoxes of the dual neurotype, and the self-acceptance Leanne reached at thirty-two.

PART II — THE ACTION GUIDE

Everything reorganised into a father's three jobs — **SEE**, **STEADY**, and **CHAMPION** — followed by a one-page Quick Reference you can keep close.

MOVEMENT



Understanding the Brain

*What AuDHD is — and how it shows up in childhood, the teen years,
and school.*



CHAPTER 01

What is AuDHD?

Two engines, opposite directions

“ADHD says yes and autism says no. If you’re exhausted listening to this, just imagine what it’s like to live it.”

IN LEANNE’S LIFE

The unicorn. Leanne’s anchoring image: a neurotypical brain is a horse — built to follow a herd; a neurodivergent brain is a zebra — wired for self-preservation and impossible to ‘break in’; an AuDHD brain is a unicorn — mystical, magical, and invisible to almost everyone.

Glasses, not a cure. ADHD medication can adjust brain chemistry the way glasses sharpen sight, but neither condition is an illness to be fixed — they’re a different operating system, present from birth, like the colour of your eyes.

Half escaping the other half. She describes the lived feeling of AuDHD as one half of her brain wildly trying to escape the other half, which just wants to figure out the rules and fit in.

THE LESSON

AuDHD isn’t ADHD plus autism stacked neatly — it’s a lifelong tug-of-war between a part that craves novelty and a part that needs sameness, producing both real exhaustion and real magic.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Lead with patience, compassion, and no judgment — the experience is overwhelming to navigate, and your steadiness matters more than your answers.
2. Remember he is who he is, not a label or a condition; the words are only there to help him understand himself.
3. Ask open-ended questions with the genuine intent to learn, and check in regularly — don’t offer your opinions or judgments unless he asks for them.
4. Don’t expect him to be able to explain AuDHD to you — he’s a child trying to understand it himself, not a medical professional.

CHAPTER 02

Childhood

‘Naughty’ is anxiety in disguise

“All it appeared externally was a little girl, but inside it felt like I was a monster.”

IN LEANNE’S LIFE

The Christmas presents. She opened all her gifts at 6am, thanked everyone when they woke, and couldn’t understand why she was in trouble — she’d been told to wait until Christmas Day, which she did. The literal rule was kept; the unspoken one (that others wanted to watch) was invisible to her.

Reading in the cubicle. Unable to face the noise and unstructured chaos of break time, she read in a bathroom stall to survive it — a quiet, costly form of coping that others read as strange.

The golden door handle. She would sit by the front door for hours, rocking, staring at the golden handle, wanting to run away to become someone new — a child carrying a weight nobody around her could see.

THE LESSON

What looks like defiance, drama, or being ‘naughty’ is usually a nervous system in survival mode. The job of the adults is to change the environment around the child, not to change the child.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Learn how AuDHD presents in a child, and help Ellis understand his own strengths and challenges — information is empowering, not limiting.
2. Explain the reasoning behind requests so he feels in control, and offer choices instead of commands ('shall we brush teeth before or after the bath?').
3. Treat his sensory needs as needs, not preferences — a clothing label or a noisy shop can be genuinely painful, and he shouldn't have to justify it.
4. Remind him, often, that he is loved unconditionally and is not broken; his brain simply works differently, and that's okay.

CHAPTER 03

Adolescence

The danger zone

"I was immensely vulnerable, open for anybody to take advantage of — all whilst blaming myself to maintain a sense of control. But I was just a child."

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

The light-bulb moment. She realised her parents couldn't actually punish her into changing — what she really needed was someone safe to talk to, someone she trusted wouldn't land her in more trouble if she opened up.

Friends, but unknown. She masked so well she had friends, but felt exhausted and unseen — liked for a performance, never for the real her.

Detention by choice. One teen she coached skipped morning chapel because he preferred detention — it gave him quiet time to do his homework. It made perfect sense to him, and none to the school.

THE LESSON

The teen years are the danger zone: puberty intensifies every trait, masking drains the tank, and an AuDHD teen who was never taught the unwritten social rules is dangerously easy to exploit. Safe adults and open conversation are the antidote.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Practise radical acceptance — difficult behaviour stems from genuine differences in how his brain works, not defiance or immaturity.
2. Have open, proactive conversations about puberty, bodies, and relationships before he needs them, and affirm whoever he turns out to be.
3. Normalise his way of socialising (one or two close friends over big groups) instead of pushing him to be 'popular'; recognise masking and its cost.
4. Seek to understand the reason behind a behaviour rather than telling him off — and make sure he knows he will never be in trouble for asking for help.

CHAPTER 04

Learning

Acing the test, feeling stupid

"I was either too quick and bored, or too slow and confused."

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

'Did you cheat?' She got straight A's and a teacher asked the class if she'd cheated. She felt like she had — a pattern-based brain that could absorb and pour out huge amounts under pressure, while she still felt stupid.

Origami and hidden books. To cope with class she'd hide fiction inside her textbooks and fold origami birds — a quiet form of stimming that kept her regulated and kept her struggles invisible.

The one teacher. A law teacher who 'seemed to understand my brain' sat her at the front, made learning feel alive, and gave warm feedback. She got 100% in that exam. One affirming adult changed the trajectory.

THE LESSON

A standardised system measures a narrow band of skills. An AuDHD child can ace an exam and still feel stupid — and his real intelligence often lives exactly where the tests don't look. The right teaching style unlocks it.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Help him explore how he naturally prefers to learn, and build on his strengths rather than grinding at his weak spots.
2. Support him to ask for accommodations (noise-cancelling headphones, extra time, dictation tools) and remember interrupting deep focus can be genuinely distressing — keep a clock in his eyeline.
3. Encourage his interests even if they're niche; he doesn't need a 'normal' job, and the things he can hyper-focus on are where he'll shine.
4. Build wind-down time after school — a day of masking often detonates the moment he's safely home, and that's not a failure, it's a release.

MOVEMENT



The Hidden Cost

*What happens to a brain like this when it isn't understood — and
how the right support changes everything.*



CHAPTER 05

Vulnerability

Brilliant and exploitable

“Your neurodivergence means you may be less aware of when you need support than others.”

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

The ‘Protect Yourself’ sign. For months she kept a sign she'd painted by her front door reading ‘Protect yourself’ — an external cue to do the thing her brain wouldn't prompt on its own.

‘You don't live on chicken nuggets’. Her gentle reassurance that the creative, simplified ways AuDHDers get through life — including around food and self-care — are valid, and can be built on, not shamed.

Crying every day. It took a friend visiting and remarking how unhappy she seemed for it to land — she hadn't realised that crying every day wasn't normal. Her own distress had become invisible to her.

THE LESSON

AuDHD makes you brilliant and it makes you exploitable — the same wiring does both. Safety doesn't come from hiding from the world; it comes from naming the vulnerability out loud and building protection around it.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Reach out even when he doesn't respond as you'd expect — he may not see the point in talking, but he'll feel that you kept showing up.
2. Give specific, direct instructions — ‘Ellis, please put the forks on the table’ lands where ‘help with dinner’ leaves him lost; don't assume he knows what you mean.
3. Quietly support the basics he may not flag — checkups, routines, and (later) money, debt, and the traps aimed at people who trust easily.
4. Body-double the dull stuff — doing a chore alongside him, or a regular shared errand, turns an impossible task into a connection point.

CHAPTER 06

Mental Health

A signal, not a flaw

“These are signals that something in your life needs to change, not end.”

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

‘To me, it was normal’. A stress rash sent her to a doctor; she insisted she wasn't stressed, that she was the happiest she'd ever been. She genuinely couldn't recognise her own internal experience as unhappiness.

The cost of going unseen. Without anyone understanding her brain, she spent long stretches not wanting to be here. She is clear that it was the loneliness and the not-understanding that drove it — the case, in her own life, for being seen early.

The hope box. One of her steadiest tools: a box filled with letters, photos, sensory comforts, and reminders of things still worth doing — opened on the hardest days.

THE LESSON

Mental-health crises in AuDHD are signals from an overwhelmed nervous system, not character flaws. The single most protective thing in the world is a person who checks in, and who can listen without panicking.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Check in proactively — he may never ask for help — and remind him he is not a burden and his feelings are valid.
2. Ask whether he wants advice or just wants you to listen, and acknowledge the sheer effort that masking takes; offer compassion when he's drained and needs to recharge alone.
3. If you're ever worried about his safety, ask directly and calmly — asking does not put the idea there, it opens the door. If he says yes, don't panic; just listen, and get help.
4. Celebrate the small wins he'll forget to celebrate himself, and point out the tiny signs of progress — a shorter hard moment, an easier morning.

CHAPTER 07

Trauma

Protect his reality

“Trauma does not define you, and you are not alone. This can explain, but not excuse.”

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

‘A bunch of letters’. In one relationship she was taught to dismiss her ADHD as meaningless letters and to reframe every upset as her own fault — and slowly lost her grip on her own reality. A cautionary tale about what happens when a vulnerable person's reality gets overwritten.

A glass of water. She rebuilt trust in herself through the smallest acts of self-compassion — a glass of water each morning — proving to herself, one tiny decision at a time, that she could take care of herself.

Felt fine, then flooded. Delayed processing meant she'd feel okay in a moment and be overwhelmed with regret hours later, realising she'd been uncomfortable the whole time. Her 'yes' didn't always mean yes.

THE LESSON

AuDHD people accumulate trauma partly because difficulty trusting their own signals leaves them open to being told their reality is wrong. Rebuilding trust with yourself, in tiny steps, is the heart of healing — and it isn't linear.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Validate his feelings even when you don't understand the trigger — 'I can see this is really difficult' goes a long way.
2. Respect his boundaries and double-check a 'yes' when you sense he may be pushing himself past what he actually wants.
3. Provide routine and predictability — a standing time and place to connect each week — and ask permission before physical touch.
4. Acknowledge his coping mechanisms without criticism; ask how they help him before offering alternatives, and stay a safe place he can always return to.

CHAPTER 08

Support

Glasses, not a crutch

"You are not broken and do not need to be fixed — but knowing about AuDHD means you can make life easier for yourself."

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

Putting on glasses. The first time she took ADHD medication, she could finally see the dust and mess everyone else always pointed out — it felt like putting on glasses. The thoughts of giving up lifted, and she could write again.

'They didn't have a printer'. People in her life refused to fill in her diagnosis forms, dismissing ADHD as invented by psychiatrists for money. The quiet pain of asking for help and being refused by the people closest to you.

A reason bigger than herself. She kept going, in part, to finish her book — to be useful to other people. Sometimes a reason outside yourself is the bridge to staying.

THE LESSON

Support isn't a crutch and it isn't a cure — it's glasses for a different kind of brain. The goal is always to make the world fit him, not to fix him.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Notice your own feelings about diagnosis and medication without beating yourself up — then take your questions to professionals rather than putting them on him.
2. In any conversation about medication, ask questions instead of offering opinions; these topics are intensely sensitive.
3. Help with the logistics — routines, appointments, advocacy — and, if you can, protect him from cost and debt; support is expensive.
4. Get your own support (coaching, therapy, other parents). It's common for parents of AuDHD kids — 'they will get out what they put in, and so will you.'

MOVEMENT



Blooming Differently

Adulthood, change, the paradoxes of the dual neurotype, and the self-acceptance Leanne reached at thirty-two.



CHAPTER 09

Employment

Fit beats forcing

“There were people in the working world who would treat me with dignity, kindness and respect, as I was.”

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

The interview she couldn't cancel. Overwhelmed, she decided to cancel a job interview but lost the executive function to actually do it — so she went. It became one of the most validating experiences of her life; they wanted to hire her exactly as she was.

Handcuffed to the office. She rented a flat she couldn't afford to quit, right by her office, to force herself to stay — ‘I thought I'd hacked my ADHD.’ A glimpse of how hard she worked to engineer her own environment.

Be yourself, not the mask. Hired as herself rather than a masked version, she could finally relax into the work — the case for letting the real person show up.

THE LESSON

Traditional work can be a minefield, but the right environment — built around his interests and his wiring — turns ‘unemployable’ into thriving. Fit beats forcing, every time.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Years from now, point him toward experience in his areas of interest — he's far more likely to flourish where he's genuinely interested than where the world thinks he should be.
2. Help him find his interests by noticing what he already gravitates to, and offer steady reassurance through processes that will feel stressful to him.
3. Practical help lands — role-playing an interview, asking for adjustments, coming along when it counts.
4. Support his choices even when you disagree — including leaving a situation that genuinely doesn't fit; his needs are real, not weakness.

CHAPTER 10

Transitions

Build the runway

“You are not lazy. This is not intentional. Your brain is working extremely hard, all the time, to adjust to its environment.”

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

Twenty-seven pages. Asked for what was probably a one-page summary, she handed in 27 pages of research — perfectionism under pressure, the autistic detail-focus and the ADHD drive colliding.

The same class, every day. She learned to harness ‘the autistic side of ADHD’ — a gym class at the same time every day, regardless of who was teaching — using sameness to steady the novelty-seeking.

Marathons into sprints. Her image for surviving change: break the marathon into sprints, each with a defined finish line, so the brain isn't asked to leap the whole distance at once.

THE LESSON

An AuDHD brain treats transitions — even good ones — as threats. Preview, predictability, and built-in transition time aren't coddling; they're the scaffolding that makes change survivable.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Don't read procrastination or disorganisation as laziness — his brain works differently, and quick or small tasks can feel genuinely harder than big ones.
2. Support him through transitions with as much certainty as you can — a recurring meetup in the calendar, household items kept in the same place, changes previewed in advance.
3. Let him wind down his own way without offering advice on how to relax — if reading, writing, or a favourite show settles him, that's valid.
4. When he's overwhelmed by choice, it's genuinely helpful to make the small decision for him — if that's what he wants.

CHAPTER 11

Paradoxes

Two engines, every day

“My ADHD part says yes to every invitation; my autistic part wants to avoid the uncertainty — so I isolate. But human connection is what makes life worth living.”

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

Yes-and-no, same person. The daily contradiction: the ADHD part wants to be friends with everyone and says yes to everything; the autistic part dreads the uncertainty of it — and the result, too often, is staying home alone.

Four phone calls a day. She coached someone who spoke to their four adult children every day yet felt unsuccessful. She told them: what you've built is the success everyone is actually working toward — love.

The ideas bank. Flooded with ideas she couldn't stop acting on, she learned to write them down in an 'ideas bank' with a set time to review — a way to honour the spark without being run by it.

THE LESSON

The two neurotypes contradict each other all day long. The work is to notice which engine is driving today — and to protect connection against the constant pull toward isolation, because connection is what makes the whole thing worth it.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Accept that he may be brilliant at some things and struggle badly at others — hold both without judgment.

2. Make socialising easy: do an activity together, plan ahead, and if he doesn't reply to you, know it's not that he doesn't care — he's very likely thinking of you.
3. Help him look toward the future when making plans, and encourage him to say no when he needs to.
4. Open up conversations about values — what actually drives the things you each do — and offer help with the tasks he finds hard.

CHAPTER 12

Diagnosis

A tool, not a verdict

"It is not an excuse. It's just an explanation."

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

'The world ceases to exist'. On a free screening call, an assessor asked what it's like when she's really interested in something. 'The world ceases to exist.' The conversation alone was profoundly validating — being asked the right questions by someone who understood.

'You don't need a label'. People she'd known for years told her she wasn't autistic and didn't need a label — the same arguments she'd already had with herself, now thrown back by others. Their reactions said more about them than about her.

Self-diagnosis is valid. Her steady reassurance: you know your own brain better than anyone, and you do not have to have a formal assessment for your experience to be real.

THE LESSON

A diagnosis is a tool for understanding and for unlocking support — not a verdict on a person. And how the people around you react to it says far more about them than it does about you.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. If you suspect something, tread carefully — share what you've learned and ask whether it resonates, rather than declaring it.
2. Model vulnerability and asking for help; your own ADHD is a gift here — talking about your own experience shows him a brain like his can be understood.
3. Treat neurodivergence as neutral, not good or bad — and be mindful of how you speak about it around him; offhand comments can land hard.
4. If he's ever assessed, it is not your fault — you did the best you could with what you had — and if he's asked to have you complete a form, take it seriously and never refuse.

CHAPTER 13

Acceptance

Just more rainbow

"There's no pot of gold at the end of the rainbow — just more rainbow."

IN LEANNE'S LIFE

Finding Nemo. Her image for the anticlimax of discovery: like the fish escaping the tank at the end of the film, finding themselves in the ocean in plastic bags asking 'what now?' There's no magic moment when the challenges vanish — just a lifelong, hopeful journey.

Forgiving the herd. Understanding her own AuDHD let her finally understand and forgive people in her life — they were struggling without the luxury of a world where more is known about neurodivergence. It explained them, even where it didn't excuse them.

Pain into purpose. Her closing turn: stop trying to be selfless to the point of having no self; be responsible for your own happiness, and watch how much easier life becomes — then do the same for others.

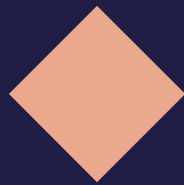
THE LESSON

There's no fix because nothing is broken. Acceptance isn't a finish line — it's the daily choice to stop fighting his own wiring. And that choice makes everything better.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ELLIS

1. Give him — and yourself — time to process; this is a real shift in how he understands himself, and however he feels about it is valid.
2. Help him notice the environments and relationships where he feels safe being himself, and gently steer toward more of them.
3. Hold the long view: there is no pot of gold, just more rainbow — and the whole game is that he gets to grow up understood at nine, not at thirty-two.
4. Turn it outward: it only takes one voice. The understanding you build with him becomes the thing he can one day offer the world.

PART II



The Action Guide

A father's three jobs: see him, steady him, champion him.



The Action Guide

All of Leanne's wisdom, pulled out of the story and reorganised into the three things this asks of you as Ellis's dad. **See** the world the way he does. **Steady** it around him. And **champion** the person he is, for the long run.

SEE

Get inside how Ellis experiences the world.

■ Read the world bottom-up

Ellis may process every detail — voices, lights, temperature, textures — before he can register 'this is a playground.' When you ask him something, give him a beat to organise the input before you expect an answer.

■ Know the two engines

Notice when ADHD is driving (novelty, yes, motion) and when autism is (sameness, no, structure). They pull in opposite directions, often within the same hour. Naming which one you're seeing changes how you respond.

■ Treat sensory needs as needs

The label in his shirt, the noise of the supermarket, the texture of a food — what's a minor annoyance to you can be genuinely painful to him. These are needs, not preferences, and he shouldn't have to justify them.

■ Reframe 'naughty' as overwhelmed

A meltdown is the fight response; a shutdown is the freeze response. Neither is a tantrum or a choice. Difficult behaviour is communication from a nervous system that has run out of room.

■ Understand the deep dive

When he's immersed in an interest, the rest of the world switches off. Being yanked out without warning is genuinely jarring — like the houselights snapping on mid-film. Give him warning and a soft landing.

■ Remember he can't always name the feeling

Feelings can build invisibly until they spill over. Help him put words to what's happening in his body rather than expecting him to arrive already able to explain it.

■ See the strength in the same trait

The detail-focus, the deep expertise, the pattern-spotting, the honesty, the resilience — these are the same wiring as the challenges, not a separate bonus. Learn to spot them in real time.

STEADY

Build the environment and the supports he needs.

■ Lower the demand, offer the choice

'Shall we brush teeth before or after the bath?' lands where 'go brush your teeth' triggers resistance — especially if there's any demand-avoidance. Choices give him the control his anxiety is reaching for.

■ Make transitions visible

Preview what's changing. Pack the bag the night before. Keep a clock or sand-timer in his eyeline. Build in transition time instead of expecting an instant switch. Change is the threat; predictability is the cure.

■ Explain the why

He'll collaborate far better when he understands the reason behind a request than when he's simply told to do it. 'Because I said so' is the one thing his brain can't use.

■ Build a calm-down kit together

Fidget tools, movement breaks, noise-cancelling headphones, a quiet corner, a weighted blanket. Co-create it with him so it's genuinely his — and so he learns to reach for it himself.

■ Protect the after-school crash

A full day of holding it together at school often detonates the moment he's safely home with you. Build in wind-down time, and don't stack another demanding task right on top of it.

■ Work with school as a team

Note what helps and request it. In the UK, explore an Education, Health and Care Plan — and keep Ellis in the conversation about his own support, so he learns to advocate for himself.

■ Make asking for help safe

He needs to hear, explicitly and on repeat, that he will never be in trouble for asking — and that you won't take any action without his say-so. That promise is what makes him able to come to you.

CHAMPION

Protect his self-worth, and play the long game.

■ Separate the child from the label

AuDHD is part of how his brain works, like the colour of his eyes. It doesn't define him and it isn't a verdict. He is your son first, always.

■ Tell him the truth about his wiring

Age-appropriately, with a metaphor he can hold — like two different operating systems. Sharing the information isn't limiting, it's empowering. Leanne's single deepest wish was to have known as a child.

■ Use your own ADHD as a bridge

You know the inside of half of this from your own life. Share it. Showing him that a brain like his can be understood — and lived with well — may be the most powerful thing you ever do for him.

■ Catch and name the strengths

He will hear far more correction than the average kid does. Deliberately reflect his passions and his wins back to him — out loud, often — so the inner voice he builds isn't only the critical one.

■ **Check in proactively; listen before fixing**

He may not come to you. Drop by, ask open questions, and offer to listen before you offer advice. If you're ever worried about his safety, ask directly and calmly, and just listen.

■ **Get your own support**

Coaching, therapy, other parents who get it. 'They will get out what they put in, and so will you.' Looking after yourself is not separate from looking after him — it's part of it.

■ **Hold the long view — just more rainbow**

There's no finish line, only a child who gets to grow up understood. Being seen at nine instead of thirty-two is the entire game. You're already winning it.

Quick Reference

One principle per chapter — the whole book on a single page. Print it, fold it, keep it somewhere you'll see it.

- 01 What is AuDHD.** Two engines, opposite directions — ADHD says yes, autism says no.
- 02 Childhood.** 'Naughty' is usually a nervous system in survival mode. Change the environment, not the child.
- 03 Adolescence.** The teen years are the danger zone. Safe adults and open talk are the protection.
- 04 Learning.** He can ace the test and still feel stupid. His real intelligence lives where school doesn't look.
- 05 Vulnerability.** Brilliant and exploitable are the same wiring. Naming the vulnerability is how you protect it.
- 06 Mental Health.** A crisis is a signal to change something, not a flaw. Check in. Listen without panic.
- 07 Trauma.** Don't let his reality be overwritten. Rebuild self-trust in tiny steps.
- 08 Support.** Support is glasses, not a crutch. Make the world fit him; don't fix him.
- 09 Employment.** The right environment turns 'can't' into 'thriving.' Fit beats forcing.
- 10 Transitions.** Even good change is a threat. Preview, predict, and build a runway.
- 11 Paradoxes.** Notice which engine is driving today — and protect connection against the pull to isolate.
- 12 Diagnosis.** A diagnosis is a tool, not a verdict. How others react is about them.
- 13 Acceptance.** There's no fix because nothing's broken. There's just more rainbow — and he gets to grow up understood.

"There's no pot of gold at the end of the rainbow — just more rainbow."

— Leanne Maskell